



SOUTH DAKOTA STATE UNIVERSITY

Office of International Affairs

OPTIONAL PRACTICAL TRAINING

Eligibility

- Maintained F-1 status for at least one academic year
- Be within the OPT application window (from 90 days before until 60 days after graduation date)
- Cannot have done a year or more of full-time cumulative Curricular Practical Training (CPT)
- Have I-20 with DSO recommendation for OPT

The Office of International Affairs recommends that students apply for OPT 90 days prior to their program end date listed on the I-20 or their graduation date (whichever is sooner).

Your OPT application must be received by USCIS no later than 30 days after the Office of International Affairs updates your SEVIS record with the OPT recommendation. Do NOT apply for OPT without the I-20 with DSO recommendation. If you do, your application will be denied and you will lose the application fee.

Furthermore, USCIS must receive your OPT Application on or before the 60th day of your grace period. Applications that are received late will be denied, which will result in a loss of status to the applicant. USCIS will not refund the application fee.

Procedure

- Complete the OPT Recommendation Request Form
- Gather digital copies of the necessary documents:
 1. latest I-94 (<https://i94.cbp.dhs.gov/I94/#/recent-search>)
 2. all previous I-20s with CPT or OPT approval (if applicable)
 3. the front and back of any previous EAD cards (if applicable)
 4. biography (photo) page of passport
 5. 2x2 (passport-sized) photo: we can help or you can go to Walmart
 6. I-20 from DSO with OPT recommendation signed by DSO and you
- Create an account at <https://myaccount.uscis.gov/>
- Apply: bring your laptop and a credit or debit card for the application fee
 - Premium processing available for an additional cost
- Go to <https://my.uscis.gov> to set up an account and activate case status alerts
- Give OIA a copy of your EAD card when you receive it



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OPT RECOMMENDATION REQUEST FORM: **STUDENT'S ACADEMIC ADVISOR OR DEAN**

US Immigration regulations require that Optional Practical Training (OPT) be used for employment related to the student's field of study. In order to issue a recommendation, we are required to obtain the following information. Please complete the sections below and return to the student. Any questions can be directed to the Office of International Affairs. Thank you for your assistance.

Student's Name: Nikhil Chaudhary Student ID: _____

Please mark the most accurate statement:

For Undergraduate Students:

- ☐ The student has completed all of their coursework.
- ☐ The student is currently in their final semester and is intending to graduate by the end of this semester

For Graduate Students:

- ☐ The student will be completing their degree by the end of this semester.
- ☐ Student has completed all of their formal coursework and only has Thesis or Dissertation credits (or its equivalent) remaining to complete the degree.

Your Name: _____

Your Title and Department: _____

Signature

Date



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Office of International Affairs

OPT RECOMMENDATION REQUEST FORM: STUDENT

Name: Nikhil Chaudhary Student ID: 101203804

Address: 815 9th Street Apt 6, Brookings, SD, 57006

Phone: 6056910292 Personal Email (not Jacks/sdstate): chaudharyn582@gmail.com

Major: Computer Science Educational Level: Master's

How many months of full-time CPT have you completed? 0

Have you ever applied for OPT before? No

CIP (In "Program of Study" section on I-20; format: xx.xxxx): 11.0101

Is this CIP STEM-extension eligible (<https://www.ice.gov/doclib/sevis/pdf/stemList2024.pdf>): Yes

1) I am requesting a recommendation for:

- ☐ Pre-Completion OPT (OPT done before coursework is complete)
- ☐ Part-time OPT (during both the vacation term and/or academic year, students are limited to 20 hours per week or less.)
- ☐ Full-time OPT (during vacation term only, 20 hours per week or more)
- ☒ Post-Completion OPT (Full-time only; starts after coursework is complete)

2) Begin to think about when you would like your OPT to begin. Students must begin their OPT within 60 days of their degree completion date. You want to choose a date far enough in the future that you have time to find a job if you have not already. However, you don't want it so far in the future that employers will be discouraged because you can't start sooner. (When you meet with an international advisor to create an I-20 with an OPT request on it, the start date will be finalized.)

Anticipated date I would like OPT to start: (mm/dd/yyyy) 06/25/2026

By signing this form, you:

1. Acknowledge you are eligible for OPT.
2. Cannot engage in on-campus employment past your program end date, even if your GA contract extends beyond that date.
3. Cannot start working until you have OPT approval, you have the physical EAD card in your possession, and the start date on your EAD has arrived.

Signed by:

Nikhil Chaudhary

Signature: F6F6704F5...

3/13/2026 | 09:42 PDT

Date